

Healthy Eating for Heart Failure

VGH Centre for Cardiovascular Health



Following a low-sodium diet is one of the most important ways to help manage heart failure (HF). For some people, your healthcare team may also recommend limiting fluids. Although these changes can feel overwhelming at first, over time you'll learn to read labels, prepare simple meals from scratch, and flavour foods in new ways. The result is healthier eating, better symptom management and meals you'll enjoy.

Why do I need to cut back on salt (sodium)?

A diet high in sodium causes your body to hold on to or retain fluid. This fluid makes your heart work harder, increases your blood pressure, can cause swelling in your feet, legs or belly and can also build up in your lungs making it harder to breathe.

Eating less sodium isn't just important for people with heart failure. A lower-sodium diet can also help support healthy blood pressure, reduce the risk of stroke and kidney disease, and improve overall heart health.

Reducing Sodium: Where Do I Start?

The goal is not to eliminate sodium completely, but to reduce your intake. Most people with heart failure benefit from aiming for **2,300–3,000 mg of sodium per day**, depending on their symptoms and medical condition. Your doctor or dietitian will recommend the sodium goal that's right for you.

As a reference, **1 teaspoon of table salt contains about 2,300 mg of sodium**. The challenge is that most of the sodium we eat is hidden in processed, packaged, prepared and restaurant foods—not in the salt shaker. Even if you don't add salt to your meals, the sodium in everyday foods **adds up quickly**, making it easy to consume more than you realize.

Key Message

Most of the sodium we eat comes from processed, packaged, prepared and restaurant foods—not from the salt shaker. Reducing sodium doesn't mean eliminating salt—it means making lower-sodium choices more often.



Simple Ways to Reduce Sodium

- Plan your meals and grocery list ahead of time.
- Buy whole, fresh or minimally processed foods more often and prepare meals from scratch. Limit convenience foods, packaged foods and salty snacks.
- Compare products. The sodium content of breads, soups, sauces, crackers and cereals can vary greatly between brands. Compare Nutrition Facts labels and choose the lower-sodium option whenever possible.
- Read the Nutrition Facts table. A **5% Daily Value (%DV)** of sodium is low, while **15% DV or more** is high. Look for products labelled "**No Added Salt**," "**Low Sodium**," or "**Reduced Sodium**."
- Instead of adding salt when cooking or at the table, flavour foods with herbs, spices, garlic, onion, lemon, vinegar or salt-free seasoning blends. Fresh herbs are another great choice. Choose lower-sodium sauces and salad dressings whenever possible. Check out [David's no salt herb and spice blends](#).
- Choose fresh meats, poultry and fish more often, and limit deli meats, bacon, sausage, hot dogs and other processed or cured meats.
- Rethink restaurant eating. Save restaurant meals for special occasions or choose lower-sodium options when dining out.
- Give your taste buds time to adjust. Small changes made over time are more likely to become lifelong habits, and you'll begin to enjoy the natural flavour of foods with less added salt.

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